TRANSPUTEC



HOT TOPICS · EU AI ACT

Ready for the AI Act.

Brussels moved some of the AI Act's deadlines, but not all of them. A practical playbook for UK organisations that sell into the EU, use AI tools sold there, or simply want to get AI governance right.

INSIDE

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A practical guide for UK organisations to the EU AI Act after the Digital Omnibus: which deadlines moved, which did not, and what to do this week, this month and this quarter.

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FOREWORD

The deadline moved. The work did not.

In July 2026 the EU changed the timetable of its Artificial Intelligence Act. The Digital Omnibus on AI pushed the main obligations for high-risk AI systems back from August 2026 to December 2027, and for AI built into regulated products to August 2028. Headlines read it as a pause.

It was not a pause. The bans on certain AI practices have applied since February 2025. Rules for general-purpose AI models have applied since August 2025. Transparency duties, such as telling people they are talking to a chatbot and labelling deepfakes, started in August 2026, and a short grace period for marking AI-generated content ends on 2 December 2026. New bans on AI that creates non-consensual intimate images start the same day.

For UK organisations the Act matters more than its location suggests. It applies to anyone placing AI on the EU market, and to UK firms whose AI output is used in the EU. Many of the AI tools UK teams use every day are built to meet it. The UK itself has taken a different route, with existing regulators applying five principles and no AI bill in the May 2026 King's Speech.[1,2] This playbook sets out what actually changed, what you need to know about the AI you build and buy, and a timeline-based plan you can start this week.



The Transputec team
Transputec

INTRODUCTION

Three questions decide how much of the AI Act lands on you.

You do not need to read 400 pages of regulation to know where you stand. You need honest answers to three questions, kept up to date.

What AI do we have?

A single register of the AI systems you build, buy and use, including the AI features switched on inside software you already pay for.

What role do we play?

For each system, are you the provider who puts it on the market, or the deployer who uses it? The duties are very different.

How risky is each use?

Banned, high-risk, transparency only, or minimal. The category sets both the obligations and the deadline.

The high-risk deadline moved by sixteen months. Most of the other deadlines did not move at all.

Use the extra time to build the inventory, the documentation and the supplier evidence that high-risk compliance needs. Do not use it as a reason to stop.

01

PART 01

What changed.

The Digital Omnibus on AI is now law. Here is what it moved, what it added and what it left alone.

01 The new timetable

02 Old dates against new

03 Why the UK should care

WHAT CHANGED

A new clock for high-risk AI, and the same clock for everything else

> **Annex III moved to December 2027. Bans, general-purpose AI rules and transparency duties did not wait.**

The Digital Omnibus on AI is Regulation (EU) 2026/1744. It was signed on 8 July 2026, published in the Official Journal on 24 July and entered into force on the third day after publication.[3] The European Commission lists 27 July 2026 as its entry into force.[4] It is adopted law, not a proposal.

Its headline change is timing. The requirements for high-risk AI systems listed in Annex III, which covers uses such as recruitment, education, credit scoring and access to essential services, now apply from 2 December 2027 instead of 2 August 2026. High-risk AI that is part of products covered by EU safety law, such as machinery or medical devices, follows from 2 August 2028.[3]

The reason given in the regulation is practical: harmonised standards and guidance arrived late, and many national authorities were not ready.[3] The obligations themselves were not rewritten. Risk management, data governance, technical documentation, human oversight and conformity assessment are all still coming.[5]

What did not move matters as much. Prohibited practices and the AI literacy duty have applied since 2 February 2025, and the rules for general-purpose AI models since 2 August 2025.[6] Transparency duties under Article 50 have applied since 2 August 2026. The Omnibus only gave providers of generative AI systems already on the market before that date until 2 December 2026 to add machine-readable marking to their output.[3,5]

The Omnibus also added. From 2 December 2026 it bans AI systems that generate non-consensual intimate images or child sexual abuse material, and it softened the AI literacy duty: organisations must now take measures to support AI literacy rather than ensure a sufficient level of it.[3]

Some things are still not settled. The Commission's guidelines on classifying high-risk systems were published as a draft in May 2026 and are not final.[7] A separate Digital Omnibus on data and privacy rules remains a proposal. Treat anything still in draft as direction of travel, not law.

WHAT CHANGED

Old dates against new

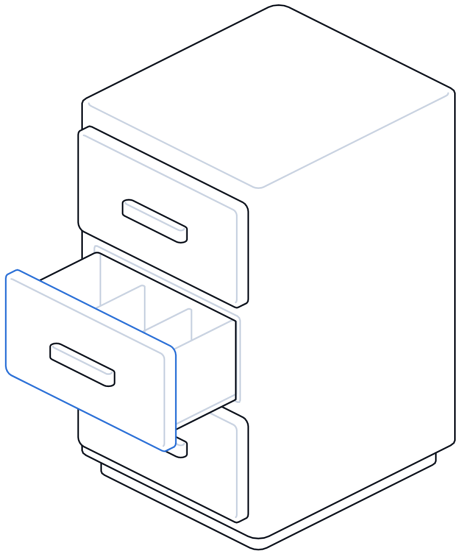
The AI Act's main application dates after Regulation (EU) 2026/1744. Status is adopted law unless marked otherwise.

OBLIGATION	ORIGINAL DATE	DATE NOW
Prohibited practices, AI literacy	2 February 2025	Unchanged. Literacy duty reworded from July 2026.
General-purpose AI models	2 August 2025	Unchanged. Commission fining powers from 2 August 2026.
Article 50 transparency	2 August 2026	Unchanged. Marking grace to 2 December 2026 for older generative systems.
New bans: intimate images, CSAM	Not in original Act	2 December 2026.
High-risk, Annex III uses	2 August 2026	2 December 2027.
High-risk, Annex I products	2 August 2027	2 August 2028.

WHAT CHANGED

Why a UK organisation is in scope

The AI Act follows the AI into the EU market, not the company's address. Four common routes bring UK firms within reach.[6]



01 **You sell AI into the EU**

Providers placing AI systems on the EU market are covered wherever they are based. High-risk providers outside the EU must appoint an EU authorised representative.

02 **Your AI's output is used in the EU**

UK providers and deployers are covered where the output of their AI system is used in the Union, for example scoring EU applicants.

03 **You run operations in the EU**

An EU subsidiary or branch using AI is a deployer established in the Union, with deployer duties.

04 **Your suppliers are in scope**

Even where you are not, the AI tools you buy are being built to the Act. Their documentation, labels and limits will reach you through contracts.

02

PART 02

Know your AI.

An inventory, a risk category and a clear role for every system. Everything else follows from these.

01 Build the inventory

02 Sort by risk

03 Provider or deployer

04 Transparency and literacy

KNOW YOUR AI

Build an AI inventory in five steps

Expect to find more AI than you think. Tie the register to procurement and change control so new AI cannot arrive unseen.

01 Ask every team, not just IT

Run a short survey: which tools, which features, what data goes in, what decisions come out. Include free tools and browser extensions.

02 Check the software you already own

CRM, HR, finance and productivity suites now ship AI features. Record which are switched on and who switched them on.

03 Record the facts for each system

Supplier, purpose, users, data, people affected, EU link, and whether output reaches customers.

04 Assign a role and a risk category

Provider or deployer; prohibited, high-risk, transparency or minimal. Send uncertain cases for legal review.

05 Give each entry an owner and a review date

A named business owner, not IT alone. Review quarterly and whenever a supplier adds an AI feature.

KNOW YOUR AI

Four risk tiers, four sets of duties

A first sort for your inventory. Final classification of borderline high-risk cases needs legal input.

TIER	EXAMPLES	WHAT IT MEANS	WHEN
Prohibited	Social scoring, manipulative techniques, untargeted facial image scraping, workplace emotion recognition.	Stop and remove. Fines up to EUR 35m or 7% of turnover.	Since Feb 2025
High-risk	CV screening, worker monitoring, credit scoring, exam marking, access to essential services.	Risk management, documentation, oversight, logging, registration.	Dec 2027 (Annex III)
Transparency	Chatbots, image, audio or video generators, deepfakes, AI-written public-interest text.	Tell people, mark output, label deepfakes.	Since Aug 2026
Minimal	Spam filters, spelling tools, internal summarising with human review.	No specific duties. Literacy and good practice still apply.	Now
GPAI models	Large models offered to others to build on.	Documentation, copyright policy, training content summary.	Since Aug 2025

KNOW YOUR AI

Provider or deployer

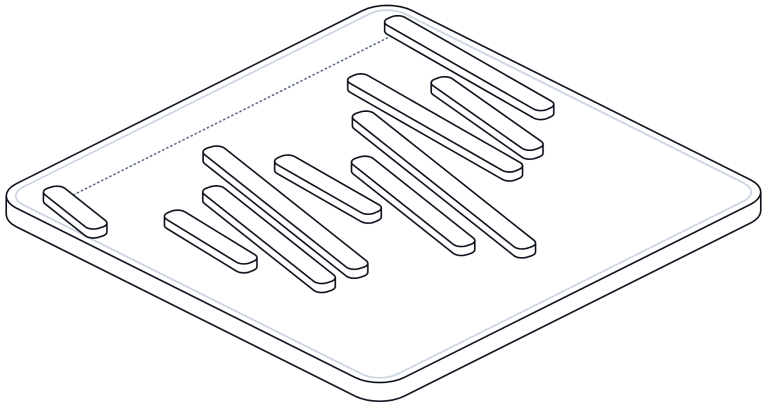
Most UK organisations are deployers. Some become providers without realising it.[6]

TOPIC	PROVIDER (BUILDS OR BRANDS IT)	DEPLOYER (USES IT)
Who	Develops an AI system, or has one developed, and places it on the market under its own name.	Uses an AI system under its authority in the course of its work.
High-risk duties	Risk management, data governance, technical documentation, conformity assessment, CE marking, registration.	Use per instructions, competent human oversight, relevant input data, monitoring, incident reporting.
Transparency	Design chatbots to disclose they are AI; mark generated content machine-readably.	Label deepfakes and AI-written public-interest text; disclose emotion recognition.
Role switch	Stays provider unless another party takes over the role.	Becomes a provider if it rebrands, substantially modifies or repurposes a system into high-risk use.
UK angle	Non-EU high-risk providers need an EU authorised representative.	Covered where established in the EU or where output is used there.

KNOW YOUR AI

Transparency and labelling

Article 50 has applied since 2 August 2026. The marking grace period for generative systems already on the market ends on 2 December 2026.[3]



01 **Tell people they are talking to AI**

Chatbots and voice agents must disclose they are AI unless it is obvious. Check every customer-facing assistant, including supplier-hosted ones.

02 **Mark generated content**

Providers of systems that generate text, images, audio or video must mark output in a machine-readable, detectable way. Ask your suppliers how they do it.

03 **Label deepfakes and public-interest text**

Deployers must disclose deepfakes and AI-written text published to inform the public, unless a person with editorial responsibility has genuinely reviewed it.[8]

04 **Use the code and the icons**

The Commission's voluntary Code of Practice, finalised in June 2026, and its EU icon set give a recognised way to show compliance.[9]

01

AI literacy: lighter wording, same good sense

The duty has applied since February 2025. The Omnibus changed it to taking measures to support AI literacy, without guaranteeing any individual's level.[3]

WHAT IT ASKS

Providers and deployers take measures to support AI literacy of staff and others using AI on their behalf, suited to their role and context.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Short role-based training, a plain-English AI policy, and guidance on checking output, protecting data and spotting misuse.

WHAT TO RECORD

Who was trained, on what, and when. Keep it with your AI inventory so you can show the link between tools and training.

COMMON MISTAKE

One generic e-learning module for everyone. Recruiters using screening tools need different guidance from marketers using image generators.

OWNER

HR and the AI programme owner

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

03

PART 03

Plan and govern.

Documentation, supplier evidence and a governance rhythm, laid out against the dates that matter.

01 A governance loop

02 Documentation that earns its keep

03 Three UK cases

04 The timeline plan

PLAN AND GOVERN

A governance loop that fits on one page

Light enough for a mid-sized firm, solid enough to grow into ISO/IEC 42001 if you choose to certify.

Own

Name an accountable executive and an AI programme owner. Agree who can approve new AI use.

Assess

Classify each new system before go-live: role, risk tier, data, people affected, EU link.

Document

Keep the evidence the tier requires: purpose, instructions, oversight, testing, supplier documents.

Monitor

Watch performance, complaints and incidents. Review high-risk and customer-facing systems quarterly.

Improve

Feed lessons into policy, training and procurement. Report to the board twice a year.

> **ISO/IEC 42001 is a management system standard for AI. The first AI Act harmonised standard, EN 18286, is designed to sit on top of it.**[10]

PLAN AND GOVERN

Documentation that earns its keep

Records you will need for the Act, and that also help procurement, audit and incident response.

AI register

Every system, owner, role, risk tier, supplier, EU link and review date. The spine of everything else.

Use-case assessment

One or two pages per material system: purpose, data, people affected, risks, controls and sign-off.

Oversight plan

Who reviews output, what they check, when they can stop the system, and how decisions are logged.

Supplier evidence

Instructions for use, transparency features, marking approach, conformity status and incident contacts.

> If you might be a provider of a high-risk system, start technical documentation now. It takes longer than any other part.

PLAN AND GOVERN

Three UK organisations, three different positions

RECRUITMENT FIRM

CV screening for EU clients

THEIR ROLE

Deployer of a supplier's screening tool, filling roles in Ireland.

RISK TIER

High-risk (employment, Annex III). Deployer duties from 2 December 2027.

DO NOW

Get the supplier's instructions for use. Train recruiters who review rankings.

WATCH OUT

Rebranding or repurposing the tool could make the firm a provider.

SOFTWARE COMPANY

Generative assistant sold to EU customers

THEIR ROLE

Provider of a generative AI system sold in the EU.

RISK TIER

Transparency. Marking for versions sold before August 2026 due by 2 December 2026.

DO NOW

Confirm machine-readable marking and chatbot disclosure against the Code of Practice.

WATCH OUT

A significant redesign can end the grace period.

RETAILER

AI images and copy in marketing

THEIR ROLE

Deployer of generative tools for UK and EU campaigns.

RISK TIER

Transparency. Deepfake labelling in force since 2 August 2026.

DO NOW

Set a labelling rule for realistic synthetic people. Brief agencies.

WATCH OUT

Borderline edits need judgement; record each decision.

PLAN AND GOVERN

The timeline plan

Work back from the dates that are fixed in law. Owners are suggestions; adapt them to your structure.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Name an AI owner. Check for prohibited uses. List customer-facing chatbots and generative tools.	COO or CIO
This month	Complete the inventory and first risk sort. Send supplier questions. Publish an AI use policy.	AI owner, procurement
By 2 Dec 2026	Confirm content marking from generative suppliers. Labelling rules live. Check the new bans.	Marketing, product
This quarter	Role-based literacy training. Use-case assessments for material systems. Board briefing.	HR, AI owner
2027	Build high-risk evidence: oversight, logs, supplier documentation. Track final guidelines.	Risk, legal, IT
By 2 Dec 2027	Annex III high-risk systems compliant as provider or deployer.	Accountable executive

QUESTIONS TO ASK

For the board, and for every AI supplier

Clear answers to these show whether you are ready. Vague ones show where to start.

FOR THE BOARD

- ? Do we have a complete, owned register of the AI we build, buy and use?
- ? Which of our AI uses touch the EU, and in which role: provider or deployer?
- ? Are any of our uses high-risk, and are we building the evidence for December 2027?

FOR AI SUPPLIERS

- ? How does your product mark AI-generated content, and have you signed the Commission's Code of Practice?
- ? Is the system high-risk under the AI Act, and will you give us instructions for use and oversight guidance?
- ? Who is your EU authorised representative, and how will you tell us about incidents and material changes?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for the AI Act?

Tick what is in place today. Anything left blank is your next step.

- [ ] **A named owner for AI governance**
  With authority to approve or stop new AI use.

- [ ] **A current AI register**
  Including AI features inside existing software.

- [ ] **Role and risk tier recorded for each system**
  Borderline high-risk cases sent for legal review.

- [ ] **No prohibited practices in use**
  Checked against Article 5, including the new bans from 2 December 2026.

- [ ] **Transparency in place**
  Chatbot disclosure, content marking from suppliers, deepfake labelling rules.

- [ ] **Role-based AI literacy measures**
  With records of who was trained and when.

- [ ] **Supplier questions sent and answered**
  Evidence filed with the register.

This checklist is a practical guide, not legal advice. Take advice on classification of specific systems.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

AI system

A machine-based system that infers from inputs how to generate outputs such as predictions, content, recommendations or decisions.

Provider

The organisation that develops an AI system or model, or has it developed, and places it on the market under its own name.

Deployer

An organisation using an AI system under its authority, other than for personal non-professional use.

High-risk AI system

A system in an Annex III use, such as recruitment or credit, or a safety component of a regulated product.

General-purpose AI model

A model trained on broad data that can perform a wide range of tasks and be built into other systems.

Article 50

The AI Act's transparency duties: chatbot disclosure, marking generated content, labelling deepfakes.

Digital Omnibus on AI

Regulation (EU) 2026/1744, which amended the AI Act's timetable and some duties in July 2026.

Authorised representative

An EU-based party a non-EU provider of high-risk AI must appoint by written mandate.

Harmonised standard

A European standard cited in the Official Journal that gives a presumption of conformity.

ISO/IEC 42001

The international management system standard for AI, usable as the backbone of AI governance.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Sources were accessed in November 2026. Dates and statuses were checked against EUR-Lex and the European Commission. This playbook is general guidance, not legal advice.

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Want a clear view of your AI estate?

Transputec helps UK organisations find the AI they already use, sort it by risk, put sensible governance around it and ask suppliers the right questions.

Book an AI governance review

transputec.com

READ THE COMPANION REPORT

The AI Act's New Clock · Intelligence report No. 15, the companion report

